

The immortal soul



Epicurus was probably the first philosopher to categorically deny that humans have an immortal soul. Working from the theory of atomism (see [Democritus and Leucippus: atomism](#)), he believed that not only is everything composed of atoms, but also there is nothing else – everything is material, and our physical death is the end of our existence. This was, and continued to be, a minority opinion.

Until the Enlightenment, most philosophers took the view that the senses and reason were separate, residing in the body and soul respectively. Plato

saw evidence for the soul's immortality in our innate knowledge of the world of Forms, which he suggested was remembered from previous existences. Aristotle also argued that although we gain knowledge through senses that disappear when our bodies die, the soul is responsible for our thoughts and can exist without a body; because it is immaterial, it cannot be corrupted and is therefore immortal. Belief in an immortal soul is essential to most religions, and a cornerstone of Eastern philosophy.